

1200–1300

SOCIAL STATEMENTS

Clothing became more voluminous in the 13th century, and men's and women's garments followed the same changes in shape. Tunic sleeves had tight lower arms, but more fabric around the armhole, and the surcoat (sleeveless overtunic) became a wardrobe staple. Though cuts were still simple and elegantly draped, headwear became more complex. Women wore hairnets, or wimples (chin bands) and circlets around the head, and men wore small, round caps. Beards went out; curled hair came in. Romance poetry with its glamorous ideals of dress and behaviour inspired women to walk gracefully with swaying hips or to hold a mantle so as to display a slim waist. Fabrics were more widely available so the leisured and merchant classes could imitate noble fashions. Such mimicry of their betters prompted litigation: laws were introduced to control what people at different social levels could wear. Called sumptuary laws, these regulations were rarely effective.

Hunting outfit This horseman, from around 1260, wears a linen coif (close-fitting cap) under another narrow, round cap, and his tunic fastens with buttons. The heavy leather gauntlet, needed for protection from the falcon's sharp talons, is decorated on the cuff.

Wedding clothes A wedding scene from around 1300 shows the main trends for women's fashion. The bride's mother wears a dress with tight cuffs but loose upper sleeves. Holding laces keep her mantle forward.

